HT and HTOED: Draft Guiding Principles

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1 The Challenge

- The HTE project: 1965-present
  - Many editors, generally carried out under the leadership of two people (both now deceased)
  - Work was flexible and emergent and rules not often written down but practice-based
  - We're trying to reconstruct it from documents and from our own heads...
- Principles all emerged from practice
  - Not imposed a priori, but discovered through engagement with data
  - "We have thus tried as far as possible to allow the classification to emerge from the data rather than be imposed upon it" (Kay 1976)
  - Principal framework is structuralist semantics

2 Theoretical Foundation: Lexical Field Theory

- Based on structural semantics approach
  - Saussure's *valeur*: meaning exists only in relation to other meanings
  - von Humboldt: language as organic system of interrelated subsystems
- Key concept: The lexical field
  - "A system of sense-relations which... is nonetheless seen as having an identity of its own"
  - Example: "Religion" overlaps with "morality," "myth," "ritual observances"
  - Boundaries are "vague and difficult to define"
- No-one has ever satisfactorily answered the question of how to determine field boundaries
  - Core items vs peripheral items
  - The problem of arbitrary inclusion or exclusion

3 Principle 1: Folk Taxonomy and Functional Classification

- *"What's it for?" rather than "What is it?"*
  - Based on "accidental rather than inherent properties"
  - Reflects human functional perspective, not philosophical taxonomy
- Example: Writing desk classification
  - NOT: *furniture and fittings* > *desk* > *writing desk*
  - BUT: *communication* > *writing* > *writing materials* > *writing desk*

- This creates classificatory tensions:
  - Where does "religious music" belong?
  - Solution: Split domains when necessary
  - Supernatural, occult → External World (explaining the world)
  - Organized religion → Social World (social construct)

4 Principle 2: The Principle of Least Extension

- "Individual lexical items are classified according to the feature of least extension"
- Core idea: Place items in the *narrowest, most specific category* that fits
- Classic example: *lava* and *volcanic ash*
  - Said to be best classified with VOLCANO, not with STONE or DUST
  - Maintains semantic precision
- BUT: Real implementation reveals complexity
  - Actually ended up in *structure of earth* > *constituent materials*
  - Shows tension between principle and practical organization
- How to handle compounds?
  - *Sea salt* under SALT or SEA?
  - *Church bell* under BELL or CHURCH EQUIPMENT?

5 Principle 3: Concrete to Abstract, General to Particular

- Overall progression: External World → Mental World → Social World
- Reverses Roget's approach (which began with abstract relations)
- Rationale: Historical development of language
  - Concrete terms likely preceded abstract
  - Metaphors for mental concepts derive from physical world
- Within categories:
  - "Begin with the most general and familiar"
  - "Work through to the most specific and technical"
- BUT: Size can override this principle if it helps the user ("principle 0")
  - Example: Cricket acquired thousands of terms, elevated from subcategory to standalone category

6 Classification Process: From Theory to Practice

- No set rules: "Each section will be different from the last"
- Typical workflow:
  1. First sort: 5-7 broad groupings + residue (Chase)
  2. Second sort: Sub-classes by "diagnostic components" in definitions
  3. Continue until "suitable level of delicacy"

- Definition-based classification:
  - Look for recurring keywords
  - BUT: Similar meanings may have different surface definitions
  - Must consider full sense including quotation evidence

7 HT Draft Classification Document: Core Definitions

- An initial attempt (Andrew, Fraser, Jane, Kate, Marc) at ordering some of our thoughts and discussions, based on excerpts from old HT documents and publications
- Central concept: Each category represents a semantic field with coherent meaning

8 New Categories: Sorting Process

- *Initial sort*: Classifiers create broad conceptual categories, some slips remain unsorted
- *Second sort*: Establishes categories and subcategories, usually settled at this stage
- *Iterative process*: Further attempts may explore different division methods
- *Hierarchical development*:
  - Save results before next round
  - Sort within categories to create new hierarchy levels
  - Use OED definitions for guidance, focus on recurring keywords
  - Consult specialist dictionaries for technical terms
- *Completion*: Repeat until all material has systematic placement

9 Category Headings: Naming Conventions

- *Primary approach*: Use current term for the concept or semantic field from category contents
- *Alternative approach*: Express relationship to parent category (e.g. 'parts of')
- *Clarity considerations*: Longer headings permissible to avoid offensive or insensitive language
- *User experience*: Consider electronic search functionality
- *Breadcrumb principle*: Headings should read coherently up the hierarchy
- *Parts of speech consistency*: Adjective categories headed adjectivally, etc.
- *Word selection*: Choose prominent, current words; avoid obscure or confusing terms

10 Ordering Principles: Structural Guidelines

- No universal rules: Each category requires individual consideration
- Coordinate relationship: Categories or subcategories at same level are equal
- Guiding principles:
  - Concrete to abstract (original Thesaurus principle)
  - General to particular (prioritised when conflicts with concrete-to-abstract)
  - Inherent arrangements: top-bottom, front-rear, size, location, importance
  - Parts or components before kinds or varieties
  - Polarity (occasionally applicable)
- Purpose: Aid user navigation, not indicate importance differences
- Category elevation: Subcategories promoted based on size, concept importance, consistency, or hierarchical requirements

11 Ordering Example (Chase): Building Parts

- Problem: How to classify parts of complex structures?
  - Church buildings: larger, less familiar, more complex than houses
  - Functional classification fails (multi-purpose spaces)
  - No constant relationship between function and location
- Chase's 'locomotive' solution:
  - Order parts as encountered on a walk through the building
  - All parts accorded equivalent status, sub-parts subordinated appropriately
- Arbitrary (different routes possible)
- Difficulty integrating peripheral structures (triforium, chapter house)
- Better than another organization? Or just idiosyncratic?

12 Word Categorisation: Classification Principles

- *Folk vs scientific taxonomy*: Prefer folk taxonomy where sensible
  - "What's it for?" prioritised over "what is it?"
  - Exception: Very technical areas (plant and animal taxonomies) require specialist approaches
  - Folk classifications more comprehensible to most users
- *Duplication rules*:
  - Word forms within same category generally avoided (legitimate exceptions exist)
  - Sense duplication avoided but considered for user findability
  - Future development may include cross-references
- *Residual categories*: 'Other types of' for single-word categories when necessary
  - Avoid where possible (lack coherent concept)
  - But sometimes only practical solution for residual words

13 Boundary Disputes

- Faith vs Supernatural phenomena:
  - Where to place witchcraft, magic, folk belief?
  - Initial instinct: All under Religion
  - Solution: Split into two widely separated categories
    - Supernatural, occult → External World (explaining phenomena)
    - Organized religion → Social World (institutional)
- Music genres and cultural categories:
  - Religious music: Music or Religion?
  - Jazz: Music or African American culture?
  - Solution: Primary classification by *function*, cross-references for *access*
- Decisions will be classificatory ideology

14 Modern Challenges: From Print to Digital

- Original constraints of print format:
  - Brief category headings
  - Rigid hierarchical display
  - No cross-references between distant categories
- Digital opportunities:
  - Longer, more sensitive category headings
  - Web-like linking structures, move beyond hierarchy
  - Multiple access points
- Current tensions:
  - Folk taxonomy vs scientific accuracy
    - Menstruation: originally "organs of excretion"
    - Now: "reproductive cycle"

15 Case Study: Social Media

- (We're going to discuss computing later, but these are notes from a presentation I gave a while ago as an example!)
- Immediate questions:
  - Under *Communication*? *Technology*? *Social Interaction*?
  - How to handle platform-specific vocabulary?
- Applying HT principles:
  1. *Folk taxonomy*: How do users conceptualize?
  2. *Least extension*: Platform-specific terms stay together?
  3. *Functional approach*: "What's it for?"
     - Communication tool? Identity construction? Information sharing?
- Can multiple classification points work?
  - Primary under *Communication*, Technical terms under *Computing*, Social phenomena under *Social Behaviour*?

16 The Paradox of Systematic Flexibility

- Core tension: Systematic classification requires consistency
  - BUT: "No set rules to follow"
  - "One no sooner sets up a general principle than one is forced to revise it"
- The pragmatic solution:
  - Consistency within domains where possible
  - Accept different organizing principles across domains
  - Musical instruments: By playing method *and* construction?
- Some obvious points:
  - Language resists rigid systematization
  - Categories must "grow out of the relevant lexical field"
  - Only *users* really matter
  - Classification as interpretation, not description

17 Other Issues in Practice

- Close reading of definitions sometimes insufficient
  - Similar meanings may have divergent definition styles
- The importance of specialist knowledge
  - When to defer to scientific taxonomy
  - When folk categories better serve users
- The value of collaborative classification
  - A classification will always be idiosyncractic, but individual idiosyncrasies balanced by team review?

18 Open Questions

- Methodological questions:
  - How to formalize "suitable level of delicacy"?
  - When does a subcategory merit category status?
  - Can we quantify the "principle of least extension"?